

ST 01: Introduction to Theology

Teaching Notes, Part 1: The Architecture of the Course

Morning Star Regional Seminary, Barrackpore For the use of the Professor

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These are your notes, not the notes of the students. They carry more than you will say aloud, so that you can teach from a full mind and choose what to give. Each section gives you the teaching content, the references behind it, the lectures where the idea returns, and an illustration you can draw on the board. Deliver the whole of this architecture on Day 1, in Lecture 1, as the contract you make with the class.

PART A: WHY SIX QUESTIONS, AND NOT A LIST OF TOPICS

Before the six goals, hold the reason for them clearly in your own mind, because a student will sense within ten minutes whether you believe in the shape of your own course.

Most introduction courses are built as a list: definition, then sources, then history, then branches. The student memorises the list and forgets it by the feast of Christ the King. The trouble is not the content but the form. A list invites storage; a question invites thought. When you frame the same content as six questions, the student stops collecting and starts searching, and a mind that is searching remembers what it finds. This is the move the contextual theologians call the shift from studying theology to doing theology, resting on the four pillars of Scripture, Tradition, faith experience, and the social context.

So you are not teaching six topics. You are teaching one argument that the students live through, and the argument has a destination, the sixth question. Keep the six written on the board, or on a poster on the wall, for the whole term. At the start of each unit, point to the one you are now answering. At the end of each lecture, ask which of the six the day has served. The repetition is not waste; it is how the architecture becomes visible to the student.

For the professor. Open Lecture 1 by reading the six questions aloud and then asking the class, before you teach anything, which of the six they think is the hardest. They will almost always pick the sixth, and that gives you your opening: the hardest question is also the most important, and the whole course is built to bring them to it.

THE SIX GOALS, ONE BY ONE

Goal 1: What is theology?

The content. This is the definitional question, and the heart of the answer is that theology is faith seeking understanding, *fides quaerens intellectum*. The word joins *theos*, God, and *logos*, word or study, so theology is God-talk, discourse on God. But the bare etymology is

not enough. Press three layers. First, theology begins in faith and experience, not in neutral curiosity; faith is the condition that makes theology possible, which is why you must ask the students whether one can do theology without faith. Second, theology is orderly and searching, so it is rightly called a science, though a science unlike the others, because its object gives himself in revelation rather than lying open to inspection. Third, theology is finally about transformation, moving from information to formation to transformation, not the gathering of doctrines for their own sake.

Illustration. Augustine on the seashore, watching a child pour the sea into a small hole in the sand, and learning that his mind could no more hold the infinite God than the hole could hold the ocean. Use this to teach the open and unfinished mind: the theologian who thinks his thought is complete has stopped being a good theologian.

References. Anselm of Canterbury, *Proslogion*, proem, for *fides quaerens intellectum* and *credo ut intelligam*. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* Ia, q. 1, for theology as a sacred science whose subject is God; the scholastic axiom that theology is taught by God, teaches of God, and leads to God (*a Deo docetur, Deum docet, et ad Deum ducit*) gathers this in one line. Roger Haight, *Dynamics of Theology*, for theology as the understanding of all reality through the central symbols of the faith. Michael Amaladoss, "Towards an Indian Theology," for theology as the believing search for an experiential understanding of God that transforms life.

Cross-references. This goal governs Unit II, Lectures 6 to 10, and it is opened already in Lecture 2 with Anselm and Aquinas. The working definition is set in Lecture 8.

Goal 2: Why do theology?

The content. This is the question of purpose, and the answer is that theology serves the believer, the Church, and the world. It serves the believer by letting faith understand itself and give an account of its own hope. It serves the Church by guarding the faith from corruption and stating it freshly in each age. It serves the world by throwing light on the great human questions of life and death, suffering and evil, liberation and redemption. Theology is therefore not a private hobby of the clever but a service owed to the community. The First Letter of Peter gives the charter: be ready to give an account, with gentleness, of the hope that is in you.

Illustration. The driving question of Lecture 1, can a priest preach without doing theology? Use the picture of two cooks. One follows a recipe he does not understand and is lost the moment a guest asks for a change. The other understands why each step is there and can adapt to any kitchen. The priest who preaches without theology is the first cook; the moment a grieving family or a doubting youth asks a real question, the recipe runs out.

References. 1 Peter 3:15, in the Revised Standard Version, Catholic Edition. Pope Francis, *Veritatis Gaudium*, proem, on the joy of truth and the restlessness of the heart until it rests in God. John Paul II, *Fides et Ratio*, opening, on faith and reason as the two wings by which the human spirit rises to truth.

Cross-references. This goal governs Unit I, Lectures 1 to 5, and it is sharpened in Lecture 1.

Goal 3: How is theology done?

The content. This is the question of method, and it is the heart of the whole course, because method shapes what the theologian is able to see. Two theologians can read the same passage of Scripture and reach different conclusions, not because one is faithless but because they begin from different places and use different tools. The answer has several parts the students must hold together: the four pillars of doing theology; the pastoral cycle of See, Judge, Act; the hermeneutic circle of Segundo, in which our questions reshape our reading of the text; and the six models of contextual theology set out by Bevens, which show that liberation, Dalit, and Indian theology are not a confusion but different models doing one work.

Illustration. The doctor. A good doctor first attends to the symptoms, then understands the pattern they make, then reasonably judges the diagnosis, then responsibly decides the treatment. Skip a step and the patient suffers. Theology has the same four movements, which is also the spine of Lonergan you will meet below. A second illustration the contextual theologians love: the worm view from the ground against the bird view from the sky, the bullock cart against the helicopter. Method decides from where you look.

References. Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (1972), for theology as a structured set of operations. Juan Luis Segundo, *The Liberation of Theology* (1976), for the hermeneutic circle. Stephen Bevans, *Models of Contextual Theology* (revised edition, 2002), for the six models. Gustavo Gutiérrez, *A Theology of Liberation* (1971), for theology as critical reflection on praxis in the light of the Word.

Cross-references. This goal governs Unit V, Lectures 23 to 29. The four precepts that order all method are taught in Lecture 12 and Lecture 23.

Goal 4: Who has authority in theology?

The content. This is the question of the sources and of authority, and the students must learn that authority in theology is not held by one office alone but is shared and ordered. Scripture is the norm that norms all others. Tradition is the living handing-on of the faith. The Magisterium is the servant, not the master, of the Word, charged with its authentic interpretation. The *sensus fidelium*, the sense of the whole believing people, is a true source that the Magisterium listens to and consults. Reason and the experience of the poor also speak. The decisive teaching is that Scripture, Tradition, and the Magisterium are so joined that none can stand without the others.

Illustration. The orchestra. The score is Scripture, fixed and authoritative. The long tradition of how the piece has been played is Tradition. The conductor is the Magisterium, who does not write the music but keeps the players together and faithful to the score. And the trained ear of the whole orchestra, which knows when a note is wrong, is the *sensus fidelium*. Take away any one and the music fails. Then pose the hard case of Lecture 14: who decides when a theologian and a bishop disagree? Schillebeeckx, investigated by Rome yet continuing his work, is the living example.

References. *Dei Verbum* 10, for the three sources so connected that none stands without the others, and *Dei Verbum* 24, for Scripture as the soul of theology. *Lumen Gentium* 12, for the *sensus fidei* of the whole people of God. Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Donum Veritatis* (1990), for the ordered bond between the theologian and the Magisterium.

Cross-references. This goal governs Unit III, Lectures 11 to 16. The precept it carries is the first of Lonergan, be attentive.

Goal 5: How has theology developed through history?

The content. This is the question of history, and the method that makes it live is to teach not dates but the question each age was trying to answer. The Gospel does not change; the questions change. The Patristic age asked who Jesus is and answered at Nicaea and Chalcedon. The Scholastic age asked whether faith and reason can live together and answered in Aquinas. The Reformation asked who saves and how. The modern age asked how to believe in a doubting, secular world. Vatican II asked how the Church should read the signs of its own time. When the student sees the history as a chain of real questions, it stops being a graveyard of councils and becomes a conversation he can join.

Illustration. The family photo album. Each generation in the album faced a different storm, a famine, a war, a migration, and you understand a grandparent only when you know which storm shaped him. The ages of theology are the generations of the family of faith, and each was shaped by its own storm. To judge the Fathers by the questions of our day is like blaming a grandfather for not owning a mobile phone.

References. Neil Ormerod, *Introducing Contemporary Theologies*, Chapter 3, for the contrast between previous and contemporary theology. *Gaudium et Spes* 4, for the duty of reading the signs of the times in the light of the Gospel.

Cross-references. This goal governs Unit IV, Lectures 17 to 22. The precept it carries is the second of Lonergan, be intelligent.

Goal 6: How do I become a responsible theologian today?

The content. This is the destination, and you must protect it, because most courses run out of time and never reach it. To be a responsible theologian is to hold together what seems to pull apart: obedience to the Magisterium and the prophetic duty to question, the rigour of the mind and the prayer of the knees, fidelity to the inherited faith and honesty before the new reality of India. It is to follow the fourth precept of Lonergan, be responsible, by deciding and acting on what one has come to know. *Donum Veritatis* describes this vocation, and the whole arc of the course is meant to form it. The word responsible is not a soft word; it means answerable, ready to count the cost.

Illustration. The Theology Manifesto of Lecture 35, in which each student stands and declares the kind of theologian he commits to becoming. Tell the class on Day 1 that this is coming, so that they read the whole course as preparation for that moment of standing up.

References. *Donum Veritatis* (1990), on the ecclesial vocation of the theologian. Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, for the precept be responsible as the summit of human

knowing. *Gaudium et Spes* 4, again, for the responsibility to read the present hour.

Cross-references. This goal is seeded in Lecture 5, where theology is named a vocation, and it returns in Lecture 25, Lecture 31, and Lecture 34, before the capstone in Lecture 35.

For the professor. Resist the urge to save the sixth question for the end. Name it in Lecture 1, return to it in every unit, and ask it again and again: given what we learned today, what would a responsible theologian do with it? A question asked thirty-five times is owned; a question asked once is forgotten.

PART B: THE SPINE, THE FOUR PRECEPTS OF LONERGAN

Who he was, and why he is the spine

Bernard Lonergan, a Canadian Jesuit who lived from 1904 to 1984, wrote two great works, *Insight* in 1957 and *Method in Theology* in 1972. His lifelong concern was the structure of human knowing, what happens when any person, in any field, comes to know something true and decides well. He found that this happens in four steps, and he gave them as four precepts. Neil Ormerod, the author of your main textbook, uses Lonergan as the compass of his whole book, which is one reason the precepts serve so well as the spine of this course. The other reason is that they are simple enough for a first-year man to carry for life, while being deep enough to order the whole of theology. And the fourth precept, be responsible, is the very word of the sixth goal. So the shape of the course is also its destination.

The four precepts

Be attentive. This is the level of experience: attend to the data, to what is actually there, before you rush to explain it. In theology this means attending to Scripture as it stands, to the living Tradition, to the liturgy, and above all to the cry of the poor, which is real data and not decoration. The sin against this precept is inattention, the theologian who does not look. *This precept governs Unit III, the sources.*

Be intelligent. This is the level of understanding: having attended, seek the insight, the pattern, the meaning that holds the data together. In theology this means asking why a doctrine took the shape it did, why an age asked the question it asked. The sin against this precept is the lazy mind that collects facts and never asks what they mean. *This precept governs Unit IV, the history.*

Be reasonable. This is the level of judgment: weigh the insight against the evidence and ask whether it is so. An idea can be intelligent and still be false; reason tests it. In theology this means judging between readings, weighing one method against another, refusing both credulity and cynicism. The sin against this precept is the clever mind that never asks whether its clever idea is true. *This precept governs Unit V, the method.*

Be responsible. This is the level of decision and value: having judged what is true, decide what to do, and answer for it. In theology this is the move from knowing to living, from doctrine to discipleship, from the page to the parish. The sin against this precept is the

theologian who knows much and risks nothing. *This precept governs Unit VI, the responsible theologian.*

Illustration. Crossing a busy road in Barrackpore. First you look, attentive to the traffic. Then you understand the flow, which way it moves and how fast. Then you judge, reasonably, the gap that is genuinely safe. Then you decide to step out, responsibly, and you answer for that decision with your life. Skip a step and you are hurt. The four precepts are simply what every careful person already does; theology asks the student to do it on purpose, and with God. Use the doctor from Goal 3 as a second version of the same image.

References. Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology* (London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1972), Chapter 1, where the four precepts are stated together. Bernard Lonergan, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding* (1957), for the fuller account of the levels of knowing. Neil Ormerod, *Introducing Contemporary Theologies*, for the use of Lonergan as the ordering principle of contemporary theology.

Cross-references. The precepts are introduced explicitly in Lecture 12, the Lonergan lecture, returned to in Lecture 23 as the order of all method, and gathered at Lecture 34 as the mark of the responsible theologian. Each precept also governs its unit, as marked above.

For the professor. Teach the precepts simply. Lonergan can be heavy, and his full metaphysics will lose a first-year class. Give the four words, the road-crossing image, and the link to the four units, and leave the deeper apparatus for later years. Four words a student can hold are worth more than forty he cannot.

PART C: THE RHYTHM OF EACH CLASS

Why this rhythm

A lecture of forty-five unbroken minutes turns the student into a passive vessel, and the vessel leaks. The rhythm you have chosen keeps the student active and makes him do the four movements of Lonergan himself, in miniature, every single class. That is the deep reason it works, and it is worth your seeing it: the rhythm of the class is the spine of the course made small.

The five phases

Ten minutes, the opening problem. Begin not with a definition but with a real question that the student feels before he can answer it. This is the attentive moment; it makes him look. Choose a problem that has no easy answer and that touches his life, as the driving questions of the course do. Pose it, let two or three students react, and do not resolve it yet. The unresolved question is the hook that holds the rest of the hour.

Fifteen minutes, the teaching. Now teach, but tightly, one or two central ideas, not ten. This is the intelligent moment; it offers the insight. Use the board, use a single illustration, and speak in plain language with gentle humour, the way a good storyteller teaches, so that

the idea lands and stays. Resist the urge to pour in everything you know; these teaching notes hold the surplus so that the class does not have to.

Ten minutes, the discussion through the reading rotation. Three students carry the assigned reading. The summariser gives its argument in two minutes. The critic names one weakness or disagreement. The responder answers the critic or deepens the point. This is the reasonable moment; it weighs and tests. You only moderate. The roles rotate across the term so that every student plays each one several times. This is also the rolling book review, which is why no separate written review is set.

Five minutes, the reflection. Silence first, then a single sentence in the journal answering the prompt for the day. This is the beginning of the responsible moment; it turns knowing toward living. Guard the silence; a first-year man is rarely given two quiet minutes, and they are where the lecture sinks in.

Five minutes, the assignment. Point to the next driving question and the next reading, eight to twelve pages, never more. This closes the responsible moment by sending the student forward with a task. End, when you can, by asking which of the six goals the day has served.

Illustration. Think of the hour as a single tide. The opening problem is the pull of the water back from the shore that makes everyone look. The teaching is the wave forming. The discussion is the wave breaking and being tested against the rocks. The reflection is the quiet of the water resting on the sand. The assignment is the tide going out again, carrying the student to the next shore. A class with all five phases breathes; a class that is only teaching is a flood with no tide.

References. The pedagogy rests on problem-based learning and on the four levels of Lonergan named above; the reading rotation puts into practice the principle from your own orientation notes that the students should speak more than the professor.

Cross-references. The rotation supplies the participation mark; the journal supplies its own mark; both are set out in the assessment document. The debates fall at Lecture 9 and Lecture 34, and the treasure hunts are spaced across the term in the semester planner.

For the professor. Two practical matters. First, keep a small rotation roster so that you, and not the eager few, decide who carries each reading. Second, when a student has not read, do not shame him; ask him instead to be the critic of what the summariser says, which still requires him to think and quietly teaches him that not reading costs something. Always err toward keeping the conversation alive.

HOW TO DELIVER THIS ON DAY 1

In Lecture 1 you will not teach all of the above; you will present its shape. Read the six questions and ask which is hardest. Give the four precepts in four words with the road-crossing image. Explain the five-phase rhythm by simply running the class that way, so that they feel it rather than hear about it. Tell them about the journal, the glossary, and the

Manifesto that waits at the end. Then turn to the first real problem, can a priest preach without doing theology, and begin. By the end of the first hour the students should know three things: that this course is a set of questions and not a list, that it is going somewhere, namely to the responsible theologian, and that they will not be allowed to sit still.

WHAT COMES NEXT

The following installments will take the lectures unit by unit, in the same style, with the teaching content, the references, the cross-references, and the illustrations for each. The next part covers Unit I, Lectures 1 to 5, Discovering Theology.

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